



Bitcoin sinks

Bitcoin, once valued at nearly \$20,000, has fallen below \$5,000 now amidst cryptocurrency crash. <https://digit.in/dec18-125-1>



Apple resumes iPhone X sales

Apple is reportedly sell its iPhone X again in light of weaker than expected iPhone XS and XS Max sales. <https://digit.in/dec18-125-2>

and to curb opposition to the war and the slave trade. Names like Benjamin Franklin are also involved.

In 1835, the New York Sun published a story attributed to the real-life astronomer. Sir John Herschel. According to the story, there was life on the moon in the form of weird man-bats and more. While this story was never intended to be taken seriously, it sold a lot of copies for the Sun and gained them almost twice their existing subscriber base. The story was debunked soon after and the Sun had to face the backlash of other publications. One good thing that came out of the widespread fake news problem back then was that people gradually became careful of what they read and share.

WORLD WARS AND THE ROAD TO MODERN TIMES

Around the turn of the century, the impact of fake news had begun to diminish. After the fake news fueled the Spanish-American War of 1898, the public demanded a verifiable source of information. The New York Times had been recently purchased by Adolph Ochs to fulfil that purpose. However, as the first World War drew closer, the rise of propaganda against rival nations also rose. The unverified story of a German corpse factory where the dead were boiled down for resources was circulated. This story was used by Goebbels during the second world war to dismiss the reports of mass execution of Jews by Hitler as 'British Propaganda'.

A famous but unrelated instance was related to the radio broadcast of an adaptation of the War of the Worlds, which supposedly sent people into panic fearing a real war-like situation in 1938. The Cold War and the Vietnam War were also ripe grounds for the involved sides to use newly available radio technology to spread misinformation far and wide. In fact, press briefings during the Vietnam war were reportedly so unreliable that they had been dubbed as Five O'Clock Follies by members of the press.

THE INTERNET

There are way too many instances of fake news having a significant real-world impact on our lives over the last couple of decades to be documented in a single article. However, if anything, the most notable situation related to this has been the spread of fake news on Facebook. In 2014, there were reports of a well-paid Russian troll army operating on platforms like Facebook and Twitter. Facebook itself has accepted that there have been paid campaigns running on its platform looking to influence the outcome of the 2016 elections. The Cambridge Analytica whistleblowing happened right on the heels of this.

Our own country hasn't fared too well either. Along with several reports of public violence against individuals based on rumours spread on What-

sApp and Facebook, there was an instance of the United Nations calling on the Indian government to protect a journalist against attacks fueled



Artistic representation of the Great Moon Hoax

by fake news and disinformation campaigns. Today, such campaigns go beyond the mere connecting power of social media. Some solutions like the distributed ledger seem to be on the horizon, but for now, we understand too little of the potential solutions. **4**

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